Research Scope & Problematization Memorandum: The Hypocrisy of Parity (Draft)

Discursive Patterns of Victimhood Signaling and Self-Serving Attribution in Exploitative Relationships

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Abstract

This memorandum establishes the formal scope, theoretical problematization, and research gap classification for the manuscript *"The Hypocrisy of Parity: Discursive Patterns of Victimhood Signaling and Self-Serving Attribution in Exploitative Relationships"*. Grounded in Swales' CARS framework and Alvesson & Sandberg's (2011) problematization methodology, this document maps three intersecting scholarly conversations, classifies the core theoretical paradox within real-world interpersonal and dyadic relationships, articulates three FINER research questions, and conducts a pre-mortem audit to eliminate fatal methodological vulnerabilities prior to full empirical deployment.

1 Scholarly Conversation Mapping

This study intervenes at the nexus of four intersecting scholarly conversations spanning Discursive Psychology, Interpersonal Communication, Social Psychology, and Computational Social Science:

1. **Conversation 1: Moral Hypocrisy & Self-Serving Attribution in Relationships.** Foundational works establish that human moral action is frequently guided by the desire to appear fair and principled without incurring the behavioral costs of sacrifice (Batson et al., 1997, 1999). In close relationships, this is reinforced by self-serving attribution and moral licensing, wherein claiming egalitarian values creates cognitive credentials that insulate actors from guilt during subsequent selfish conduct (Monin and Miller, 2001; Merritt et al., 2010; Krettenauer, 2022).

2. **Conversation 2: Discursive Psychology, Blame Management, & Interpersonal Accounts.** Research in discursive psychology and interpersonal communication demonstrates that language in dispute situations functions as a performative social action (Edwards and Potter, 1992; Billig, 1996). Actors systematically deploy conversational accounts, justifications, and excuses (Scott and Lyman, 1968) to manage accountability, discursively construct victimhood, and deflect responsibility for relationship friction.

3. **Conversation 3: Interpersonal Exploitation, Dark Personalities, & Weaponized Signaling.** Recent research in personality psychology demonstrates that subclinical Dark Triad traits actively deploy virtuous victimhood and dominance-based moral grandstanding to secure relational control, emotional compliance, and unearned partner accommodations (Ok et al., 2021; Bates et al., 2024; Cerulli et al., 2026; Savejnarong et al., 2022).

4. **Conversation 4: Computational Social Science & Large Language Models as Cultural Informants.** Advances in NLP establish that LLMs can accurately capture

pragmatic context, decode subtle interpersonal gaslighting, and identify latent semantic tensions across massive unstructured relationship narratives, bypassing self-report social desirability bias (Ziems et al., 2024; Argyle et al., 2023; Grossmann et al., 2023, 2024).

2 Problematization: Beyond Gap-Spotting

Traditional research on relationship equity and domestic labor relies on simple *gap-spotting* (e.g., investigating whether gender roles are more equal in a specific demographic). Following Alvesson and Sandberg (2011), this study pursues **problematization** by challenging the foundational assumption shared by contemporary relationship science:

> *Conventional Assumption:* Vocal demands for 50/50 equality, emotional labor sharing, and relationship fairness reflect prosocial dyadic commitment aimed at reducing relational friction.

Problematized Axiom (First Principles): In interpersonal relationships and the treatment of others, egalitarian vocabulary is structurally optimized to serve as an offensive instrument of interpersonal leverage. Far from promoting equity, high-frequency parity demands combined with victimhood signaling actively lower the perceived moral cost of exploiting others by establishing moral credentials and pre-empting accountability.

3 FINER Research Questions

Applying the FINER criteria (*Feasible, Interesting, Novel, Ethical, Relevant*) and safeguarding against Type III errors (Alvesson and Sandberg, 2011), the inquiry is anchored by three core questions:

- **RQ1 (Parity Demands vs. Relational Extraction):** To what extent does high-frequency deployment of Egalitarian Vocabulary & Parity Demands (*EVP*) correlate with Exploitative Interpersonal Relationship behaviors (*EIR*) in observed relationship dispute disclosures, and is this association mediated by Self-Serving Attribution & Licensing (*SSA*)?
- **RQ2 (Victimhood as an Interpersonal Lever):** How does Virtuous Victimhood Signaling (*VVS*) moderate the relationship between parity rhetoric and self-serving justifications, enabling actors to extract concessions while neutralizing resistance in their treatment of others?
- **RQ3 (AI Cultural Informant Decoding):** How effectively do multi-model Large Language Model architectures, functioning as synthesized cultural informants, detect, categorize, and quantify latent semantic dissonance between claimed egalitarian ideals and enacted exploitation of others?

4 One-Line Scholarly Contribution

> **The Contribution Formula:** *Before this study*, relationship scholarship assumed that vocal advocacy for equality was an unalloyed indicator of prosocial relationship commitment; *we demonstrate that* parity rhetoric is strategically operationalized as an exploitative lever in the treatment of others that licenses mistreatment; *this matters because* clinical counselors and relationship assessment instruments currently treat progressive fluency as prosocial, blinding them to therapeutic gaslighting and interpersonal predation.

5 Pre-Mortem Risk Audit & Structural Countermeasures

Conducting a strict `/premortem` audit reveals three fatal rejection risks and their proactive remedies:

Potential Fatal Risk	Vulnerability Mechanism	Proactive Hardening Strategy
1. Conflation of Sincere Equity vs. Weaponized Parity	Reviewers argue that not all demands for fairness are insincere, risking false-positive classification.	Implement a dual-axis distance metric: isolate linguistic proximity of fairness vocabulary directly preceding documented non-cooperative, asymmetric relationship actions.
2. LLM Hallucination / Bias as Cultural Informant	LLMs might project Western sociolinguistic training biases onto naturalistic relationship text.	Triangulate 3 independent model families (OpenAI, Anthropic, Google) with temperature $T = 0.1$ and cross-validate against expert human clinical coders.
3. Ethics of Forum Data Scraping (IRB / PDPA)	Ethical scrutiny over analyzing public relationship disclosures.	Ensure complete anonymization, cryptographically hash user identifiers (SHA-256), remove all PII, and operate under IRB-exempt public repository guidelines.

Table 1: Pre-Mortem Vulnerability Analysis and Methodological Safeguards.

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